

film reviews Laugh Out Loud

LOINS OF PUNJAB PRESENTS

Director: Manish Acharya
Starring: Shabana Azmi, Ayesha Dharker

The superbly titled *Loins of Punjab Presents* is about a singing contest called Desi Idol, held in New Jersey. At one point, the gargantuan Patel family, determined that their Preeti should win, try to influence the vote by showing one of the judges "a good time". They take him to a striptease joint. As the flamboyantly gay man holds his head, father Patel asks, "You want some Coke?" pronouncing



SPARKLING ACT: Shabana Azmi (right)

Coke in a way that means something else entirely.

Loins is perhaps the funniest film released this year. But debutant director Manish Acharya isn't just aiming for a few laughs. He and his co-writer Anuvab Pal also intelligently weave in subtexts about Indian

identity, belonging, reverse racism (the Indians are affronted when an American auditions for Desi Idol) and of course the tenacious hold of Bollywood. *Loins* lacks craft or technical finesse. But it has a big heart and a sparkling script.

by Anupama Chopra

Moody Intrigue

MANORAMA SIX FEET UNDER

Director: Navdeep Singh
Starring: Abhay Deol, Raima Sen, Vinay Pathak, Gul Panag

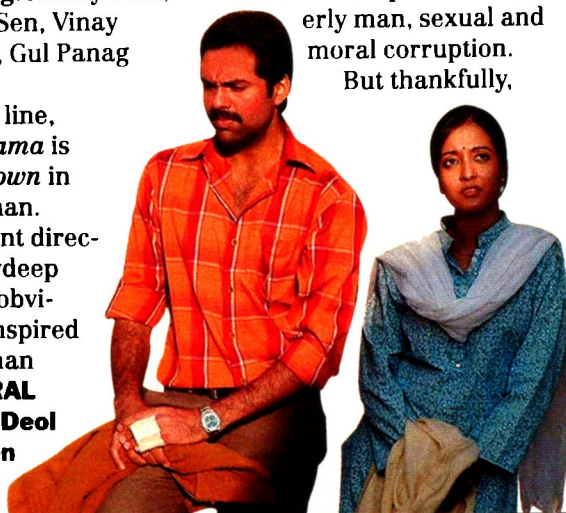
In a line, *Manorama* is *Chinatown* in Rajasthan. Debutant director Navdeep Singh, obviously inspired by Roman **NATURAL NOIR:** Deol and Sen

Polanski's 1974 noir classic, creates murder, mystery and deception in a small, dusty town called Lakhot. Like *Chinatown*, there are land deals, dead bodies, a powerful elderly man, sexual and moral corruption. But thankfully,

Singh doesn't settle for mere imitation. Instead he creates a moody, textured world, which seems downright mundane (note Gul Panag's dowdy night-ies) but is actually seething with intrigue.

Abhay Deol, playing the writer-turned-amateur-detective, is a natural—no showy acting on display here. His co-stars, especially Vinay Pathak, are equally good. *Manorama's* plot is overtly convoluted. It doesn't have the grace or gravitas of *Chinatown*. Still, the film is worth watching for its ambition, ambience and performances.

by Anupama Chopra

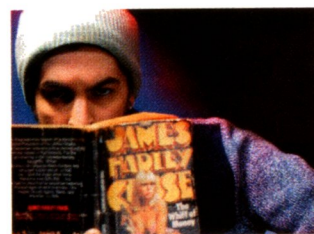


Sweet Suspense

JOHNNY GADDAAR

Director: Sriram Raghavan
Starring: Neil Nitin Mukesh, Dharmendra

Sweet-faced hunks don't usually make their debut in a taut thriller where they play a James Hadley Chase loser. Which is the first surprise in this twist-and-turn hedunnit about a gang of crooks that doffs its hat to *Parwana*, *Scarface* and



HERO AS LOSER: Mukesh

Johnny Mera Naam while eliminating its cast one by one. Every time it looks as if Mukesh's good sense will assert itself, his inner demon takes control. Every time it seems the film will descend into pure homage, Raghavan does a clever detour. The writing of the film is superb ("it's not the age, it's the mileage," says Dharmendra) and the mood, dark. Mukesh, grandson of the legendary singer whose name he shares, needs films to match his talent. Raghavan, who directed *Ek Hasina Thi*, needs producers who understand his sly wit.

by Kaveree Bamzai



It's a small world after all.
Thanks to my amazing wireless technology.



Intel® Centrino® Duo Processor Technology. Discover more at www.intel.com/in/greatcomputing
GREAT COMPUTING STARTS WITH INTEL INSIDE.

©2007 Intel Corporation. All rights reserved. Intel, Centrino, Core Inside, and Intel logo are trademarks of Intel Corporation in the U.S. and other countries